al through school, we were taught to read, write and speak, but never to listen, and the situation remains much the same today. Traditional y, Indian scientists have been very good speakers, but have inadequately developed listening skil s. We made a resolution to be attentive listeners. Are engineering structures not built on the foundation of functional utility? Does technical know-how not form its bricks? And, are these bricks not put together with the mortar of constructive criticism? The foundation had been laid, the bricks baked, and now the mortar to cement our act together was being mixed.

We were working on the action plan that had emerged from the earlier month's review, when the news of Shrimati Gandhi's assassination broke. This was fol owed by the news of widespread violence and riots. A curfew had been imposed in Hyderabad city. We rol ed up the PERT charts and a city map was spread out over the table to organize transport and safe passage for al employees. In less than an hour, the laboratory wore a deserted look. I was left sitting alone in my office. The circumstances of Shrimati Gandhi's death were very ominous. The memories of her visit barely three months ago further deepened my pain.